AI Use Among Sociology Faculty

Graduate Program in Sociology, Purdue University · Summary of the fall 2026 faculty survey
Data analysis and report generated with Claude Code (Anthropic), under the direction and review of the department

> **About the survey.** An anonymous Qualtrics survey asked faculty whether they used AI tools (LLMs such as ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini, or AI agents such as Claude Code, Codex or Cursor) in their **research**, **teaching** and **service** over the past year, and how often for specific tasks. **26 of 31 faculty responded (84%)**; 23 wrote open-ended comments. Task questions were shown only to those who used AI in that area, so task results describe *users*, not all faculty. Read the counts, not just the shares.

Figure 1. Faculty use of AI by area of work, past year

All 26 respondents; check-all-that-apply, so 'LLM and AI agent' means both

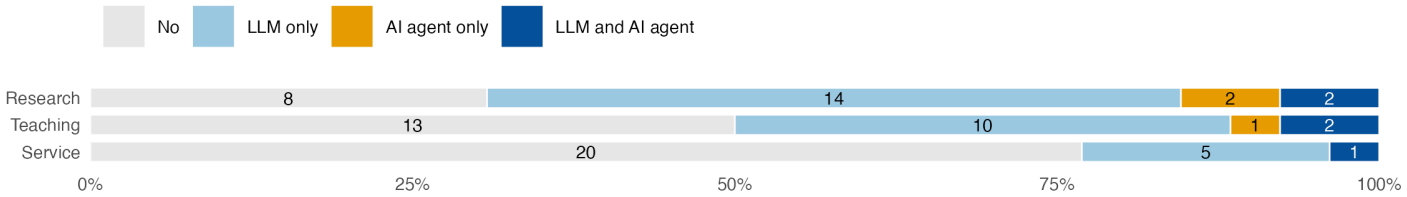


Figure 2. AI use in research, past year

Among the 18 who used AI in research (n = 17-18 per item); ordered by number reporting any use

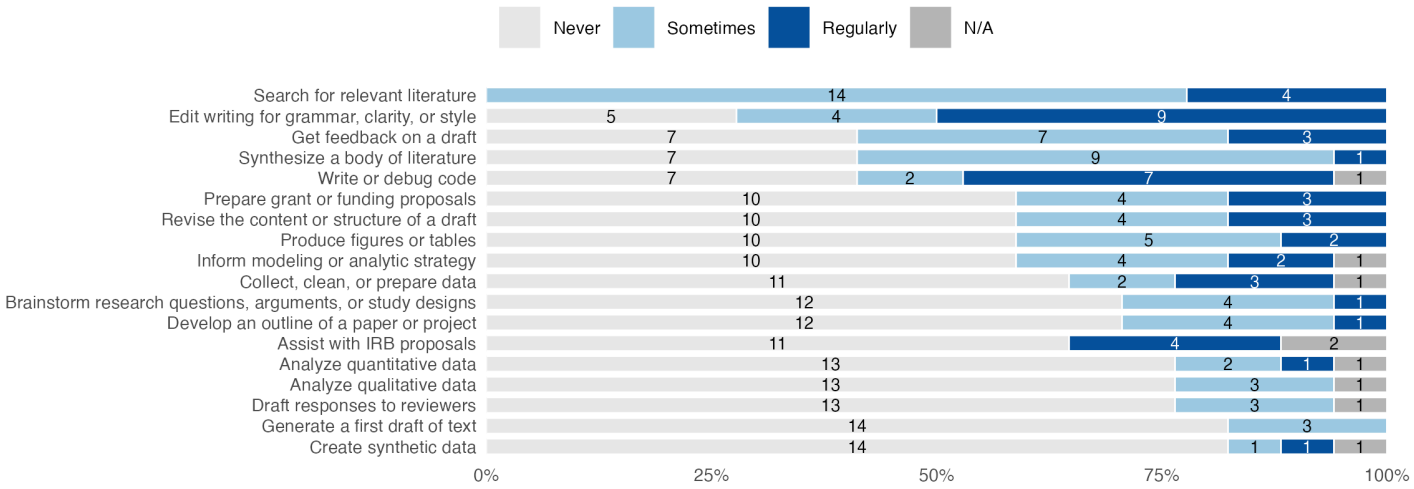
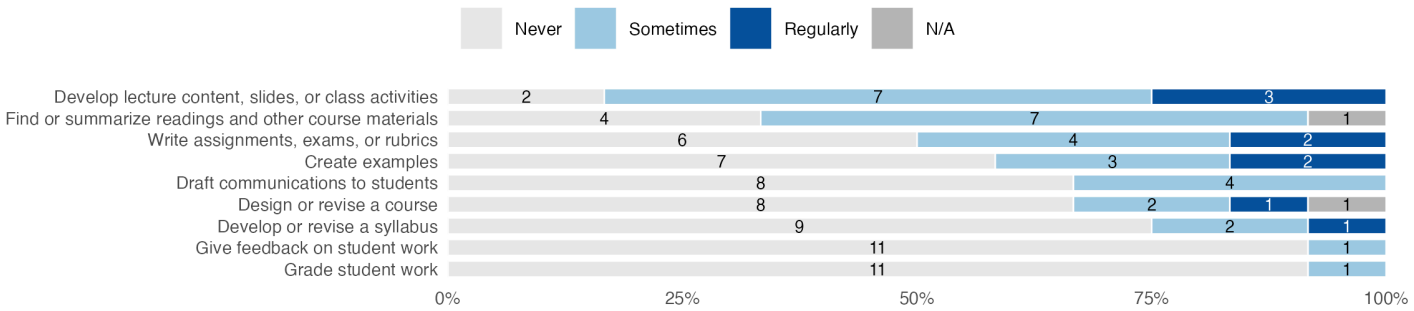


Figure 3. AI use in teaching, past year

Among the 13 who used AI in teaching (n = 12 per item); ordered by number reporting any use



Key observations

- **Use varies by area.** 18 of 26 respondents used AI in research, 13 in teaching and 6 in service. 5 used it in none of the three areas and 4 in all three. AI agents were used by 4 in research, 3 in teaching and 1 in service.
- **Research use centers on finding, editing and coding.** All 18 research users used AI for literature searching (4 regularly); 13 of 18 for editing (9 regularly), 10 for feedback on a draft, 10 for synthesizing literature and 9 for code (7 regularly).
- **Drafting and data analysis are uncommon.** 3 of 17 used AI to generate a first draft of text; 3 analyzed quantitative data and 3 qualitative data.
- **Teaching use is mostly for preparation.** 10 of 12 teaching users used AI for lecture content, slides or activities and 7 for finding or summarizing readings; 1 used it for grading and 1 for feedback on student work.
- **Service use is limited to 6 people.** All 6 used AI for letters of recommendation (1 regularly); other service tasks were used by 3 or fewer.

What faculty say about how they decide

Selected verbatim comments from the open-ended questions (identifying details removed). Themes are the analyst's reading of the 23 respondents' comments.

1. AI as a supervised assistant, with judgment kept in human hands

> *"I direct it and check its work, but I give it specific tasks that I know it is good at and/or that would be tedious and time consuming for me to do. I do not yet feel comfortable -- and may never -- having it produce the ideas or do the writing."*

> *"I use AI fairly heavily, but never as a fire-and-forget solution. Instead, I generally engage in a dialog with AI, much as I might engage in a dialog with a grad RA."*

> *"In any case, I check out all responses with follow up questions, including doubts and contradictions."*

> *"If AI can do it easily or well, I change the assignment if possible."*

2. Where some draw the line: teaching judgment, confidentiality and ethics

> *"I never use it for grading, feedback, or for writing emails, all of which I feel should come from me directly."*

> *"it may be unethical to put primary data into AI models (i.e., for reasons of confidentiality)."*

> *"I have questions about the ethical use of AI in qualitative research where assurances of confidentiality is part of the process of receiving IRB approval."*

3. Learning needs and uncertainty about how to use AI well

> *"I would be interested in a training/workshop specific to understanding how students are using it (as opposed to a workshop how to incorporate it into my teaching)."*

> *"I experimented with a few things but have not found AI effective in doing the tasks I wanted to be done. I need to learn more about various AI tools."*

> *"I hope to use AI for more labor saving well defined concrete tasks over time … because I haven't yet learned efficient ways to make it work for me."*

Quotes are verbatim from the de-identified data (spelling and punctuation unchanged). Some are excerpts that begin or end mid-sentence.